The Stages of the Feast Gathering Offering

Gaṇacakrapūjākrama · Toh 1258 · Derge Tengyur
ཚཝོ་སྐྱེས་ཀྱི་འཁོར་ལོའི་མཆོད་པའི་རིམ་པ

The Stages of the Feast Gathering Offering, known in Sanskrit as the Gaṇacakrapūjākrama and in Tibetan as Tshogs kyi 'khor lo'i mchod pa'i rim pa, is a concise tantric ritual manual setting out how to conduct a feast gathering, or gaṇacakra, a communal offering through which practitioners gather the accumulations of merit and wisdom and pacify obstacles. Opening with homage to the noble Avalokiteśvara, it guides the participants step by step, from preparing the feast house and receiving the vajra master, through the admission of the yogins and yoginīs, the blessing of the vajra and bell, the liquor and the offerings, and the invocation of the field protectors and mātṛkās, to the sharing of the feast, the offering of the remainders, and the closing dedication. Its colophon attributes it to the master Kṛṣṇa and records that it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian scholar Kṛṣṇapaṇḍita together with the translator Gö Lhatsé. It is Toh 1258 in the Tengyur, where it is found among the commentaries and ritual works on the tantras.

In the language of India: ga na ca kra pū jā kra ma. In the language of Tibet: The Stages of the Feast Gathering Offering.

Homage to the noble Avalokiteśvara.

In order to gather the accumulations
and to pacify obstructors,
I shall write of the feast gathering, the culmination of merit,
in accordance with scripture and instructions.

Here, first of all, in a delightful place, a feast house suited to the tradition and perfumed with the fragrance of sandalwood and the like, the activity master, possessing the pride of the deity, should sprinkle purifying water, make a maṇḍala, scatter flowers, arrange the offerings, and set out a large torma for the guardians of the directions.

Then the master is invited and requested to take his seat, together with his consort as is fitting. The all-activity vase, adorned with ornaments, is blessed, and the offering vases too are arranged as appropriate.

Then all the yogins and yoginīs who are fit to attend gather together. They first make this supplication:

"Wrathful one, blue and beautiful,
you are the delightful samaya,
holding in your hand a staff
bound with precious jewels.
In order to free me from saṃsāra,
hero, by your leave, please let me pass.
Into the midst of the assembly of yoginīs,
open this excellent door and let me through."
Having supplicated thus, they are drawn inside, sprinkled with water from the activity vase, and given a palmful of water to drink.

Then, having been seated in rows in proper order, they offer flowers to the vajra master and make supplication. Flowers should also be scattered over the yogins and yoginīs, and they should be exhorted.

Then the vajra master, meditating on himself as his chosen deity, blesses his tongue and hands, even if only through conviction. Then he blesses the vajra and the bell as well, from hūṃ and a, reciting the verses of their true nature:
hūṃ The being without beginning or end,
Vajrasattva, the tathāgata,
Samantabhadra, the self of all,
Vajra Pride, chief of lords.
oṃ mahā vajra hūṃ
a Because the intrinsic nature of existence is pure,
it is pure from the very beginning by its essential nature.
Through the being whose intrinsic nature is pure,
existence is made supremely excellent.
mahā vajra ghaṇḍa hoḥ

Then all the special offerings are blessed with the three syllables. Then, by the light rays of the seed syllable at the heart, the deities, whichever they may be, together with the holy guru, are beheld in the sky. Offer them welcoming water, cooling water for the feet and water for bathing the feet, and worship them in sequence with flowers and the rest, up to music. Then praise them with the Five Principles or whatever text applies. Make offering with the seven limbs, in either the extensive or the brief form, and continue up to the aspiration prayer. With the hundred-syllable mantra, ask their forbearance and request them to depart.

Then, having meditated on emptiness with the śū nya mantra, visualize the light of the syllable hūṃ as a net, a fence and a ground. Beneath that, visualize the stacked elements and the precious Mount Meru, and upon it, at the center of a multicolored lotus, imagine a crossed vajra. At its center, from bhrūṃ, generate the celestial palace together with its seats. Invite the wisdom being of whichever deity it is, and dissolve it inseparably. Then the protecting and blessing of the liquor should be done according to the text. With a red syllable ha its color is purified, with a white hoḥ its odor is removed, and with a blue hrīḥ its potency is destroyed; then imagine that it has become the nature of nectar, and with the light rays of that very syllable summon nectar as well and dissolve it in.

Then worship the deities of the root maṇḍala, naming each by name. After that, with the ring finger dipped in nectar, draw a triangular maṇḍala, and by sprinkling nectar upon it, imagine that it becomes moon seats in the directions and intermediate directions. There, imagine the wisdom wheel, even if only through conviction, and worship it with nectar. Then make offering to oneself, sprinkling with the thumb and ring finger on the tip of the tongue, between the eyebrows and on the crown of the head. Then, imagining these as without any reference point, worship the root maṇḍala with all the special articles of offering, beginning with welcoming water.

Make praises with the Five Principles or whatever text applies, and request them to depart. Then offer a large torma to the field protectors (kṣetrapālas): having purified it with the three syllables, made it blaze and visualized it, draw four lines across a maṇḍala to make nine squares. In the central one imagine the wisdom wheel, and in the directions and intermediate directions invite the eight field protectors together with the thirty-two mātṛkās, and worship them:

oṃ You who dwell in solitary trees and charnel grounds,
in mountains and in mountain caves,
in towns and at crossroads,
and especially in empty houses,
in the vessels of outcastes and on the plains,
and especially in the waters:
the Black One, the Fierce One, the Greatly Fierce One,
those who keep company with Śakra (Indra),
the Black Fanged One and the Ugly One,
and the vināyakas who are Beyond Joy;
she who brings old age, the Fierce Goddess,

the Ugly Goddess and Umā,
Jayā and Vijayā,
Ajitā and Aparājitā,
Kālī, Bhadrā, Mahākālī,
the Stout Black Goddess and Yoginī,
Indrāṇī and the Moon Goddess,
the Fiercely Hostile One and the Pendulous Goddess,
Hārītī and the Lamp Goddess,
the Terrifying One, the yoginī who dwells in villages,
she of fierce form and she of great form,
the Bared Fangs and the Great Skull,
she who wears a garland of skulls and the Crow-Faced One,
the Great Emanation, she who holds a sword, she who holds an axe,
she who holds a vajra and likewise she who holds a bow,
and likewise the five great ḍākinīs,
she who accomplishes all activities accordingly,
and likewise Vajreśvara, the chief,
the great body of the tathāgatas,
the stainless one who bestows yoga:
by the command of the Vajra Queen,
all of you without exception, gather here!
oṃ kakkaḍhana babbanadhana khakhkhāndana sarba duṣṭananaṃ hana hana ghātaya ghātaya amoghasa hūṃ jaḥ

Having summoned them with this, imagine them residing on the petals of a lotus, and present to them the offerings that were blessed earlier. Imagining that the tongue of each has become a vajra from hūṃ, imagine that they draw up the offerings through the light of its tube, and that they are thus worshipped. Then teach the Dharma, reciting the verse beginning "Phenomena are like reflections, pure and clear." Then make aspiration:

May all sentient beings be free of wrongdoing,
may all sentient beings be happy,
and by whatever path beings travel,
may they meet with buddhahood itself.
Those who have not crossed I shall bring across,
and those not yet freed I shall free;
right now, out of loving care,

I shall establish them in the abode of the yoga teachings.

Having made the dedication with this, do not request them to depart.

Then all the yogins and yoginīs, regarding one another as the maṇḍala of deities, worship the senses with scent. Then worship properly with flowers, incense and lamps. After that, worship with liquor containing the five nectars: holding the liquor in the right hand and forming the left hand into a trident, give it with this verse:

Look! This is the beautiful, sublime Dharma;
about this there is no doubt.
Brahmin, dog and outcaste, the three:
realizing them as one in nature, eat.

Having recited this, serve it. The one who receives it says:

Through desire that is free of stain,
the Dharma that has come well from the priceless,
wholly abandoning grasped and grasper:
to suchness I bow.

Saying this, receive it with the lotus-turning gesture. When serving those of lower rank, say this:

For the sake of the accomplishment of union,
the yogin engages fully
in every conduct, just as it truly is;
therefore conduct yourselves accordingly.

Having said this, distribute it. After that, worship with meat broth and butter. Then the deity portions are counted out one by one, and all of them collect the choicest first portions and offer them to the master. The master divides these into two parts. One part is placed on the left side, blessed, and offered to the deities of the maṇḍala. One part is placed on the right, blessed, and offered as the torma of the Dharma protectors, worshipping with the mantra oṃ akāro mukhaṃ. Then enjoy and partake at ease. At that time, recite verses of auspiciousness.

Then receive the light of the deities and the guardians of the directions, ask their forbearance, and request them to depart with vajra muḥ. Ask the forbearance of the wisdom deities with the hundred-syllable mantra and request them to depart with vajra muḥ. Gather the samaya deities into the

heart, gathering them with oṃ ātma diśi hūṃ. Then request the outer deities to depart with oṃ sarba duṣṭa na gṛhna gaccha hūṃ.

Then gather the remainders. These are of two kinds. The remainder of the yogins and yoginīs is given to the outer non-humans, the piśācas and the rest: it is carried out through the outer door and given away. The remainder of the householders is dedicated to the non-humans of that very house. To one who has no share of such remainders, nectar is given from the master's mouth. Then recite auspicious verses and aspirations for the patron. Then, when those who carried out the torma return, they are honored at the door of the feast house with a mirror, the blowing of smoke, the playing of music, and curd and rice with water. Then, having returned inside, the yogins and yoginīs should likewise be honored.

For people of the future who wish to gather the accumulations,
and for yogins who have entered the path of training,
in accordance with the truly stainless scripture and the guru's instructions,
holding them without error, I have written this to benefit myself and others.

The Stages of the Feast Gathering, composed by the master Kṛṣṇa, is complete. It was composed by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇapaṇḍita and translated by him together with the translator Gö Lhatsé.

Translator's Notes

• "The Five Principles" renders □□□□□□□□□□, apparently a hymn or text of praise used in the rite; its identification is uncertain. "Vajra Pride" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ in the vajra blessing verse, an epithet of Vajrasattva.
• Many of the field protectors and mātṛkās in the invocation are given in the Tibetan only by translated epithets that could not be securely matched to Sanskrit names; these are rendered by their meanings (the Black One, the Fierce One, Beyond Joy, the Moon Goddess, the Pendulous Goddess, and so on), while those with standard identifications are given in Sanskrit. "Receive the light" renders □□□□□□□□□□ literally; its precise ritual sense here is uncertain. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□, "remainder".

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please

consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.